

crest in front of our bridges on the south bank of the Po. Here they formed line of battle, throwing up hastily a light line of breast-works of rails and such other materials as they could collect on the ground. In a few minutes they were prepared to resist the enemy should he overpower Brooke and Brown and attempt to carry the bridges. I directed that all the batteries on the south side of the river, save Arnold's (A) First Rhode Island, should cross to the north bank and take position commanding the bridges. These dispositions had scarcely been completed when the enemy, having driven in the skirmishers of Brooke's and Brown's brigades, pressed forward and occupied the breast-works in front of them, then advancing in line of battle supported by columns, they attacked with great vigor and determination, but were met by a heavy and destructive fire, which compelled them to fall back at once in confusion with severe losses in killed and wounded. Encouraged, doubtless, by the withdrawal of Miles' and Smyth's brigades from our front line, which it is supposed they mistook for a forced retreat, they reformed their troops and again assailed Brooke's and Brown's brigades. The combat now became close and bloody. The enemy, in vastly superior numbers, flushed with the anticipation of an easy victory, appeared to be determined to crush the small force opposing them, and pressing forward with loud yells forced their way close up to our line, delivering a terrible musketry fire as they advanced. Our brave troops again resisted their onset with undaunted resolution. Their fire along the whole line was so continuous and deadly that the enemy found it impossible to withstand it, but broke again and retreated in the wildest disorder, leaving the ground in our front strewn with their dead and wounded. During the heat of this contest the woods on the right and in rear of our troops took fire. The flames had now approached close to our line, rendering it almost impossible to retain the position longer.

The last bloody repulse of the enemy had quieted him for a time, and during this lull in the fight General Barlow directed Brooke and Brown to abandon their position and retire to the north bank of the Po. Their right and rear enveloped in the burning wood, their front assailed by overwhelming numbers of the enemy, the withdrawal of the troops was attended with extreme difficulty and peril; but the movement was commenced at once, the men displaying such coolness and steadiness as are rarely exhibited in the presence of dangers so appalling. It seemed, indeed, that these gallant soldiers were devoted to destruction.

The enemy, perceiving that our line was retiring, again advanced, but were again promptly checked by our troops, who fell back through the burning forest with admirable order and deliberation, though in doing so many of them were killed and wounded, numbers of the latter perishing in the flames.

One section of Arnold's battery had been pushed forward by Captain Arnold during the fight to within a short distance of Brooke's line, where it had done effective service. When ordered to retire the horses attached to one of the pieces, becoming terrified by the fire and unmanageable, dragged the gun between two trees, where it became so firmly wedged that it could not be moved. Every exertion was made by Captain Arnold and some of the infantry to extricate the gun, but without success. They were compelled to abandon it. This was the first gun ever lost by the Second Corps. Brooke's brigade, after emerging from the wood, had the open plain to trav-

erse between the Block house road and the Po. This plain was swept by the enemy's musketry in front and by their artillery on the heights above the Block house bridge on the south side of the river.

Brown's brigade in retiring was compelled to pass through the entire wood in its rear, which was then burning furiously. Although under a heavy fire it extricated itself from the forest, losing very heavily in killed and wounded. Colonel Brown crossed the river some distance above the pontoon bridge, forming his troops on the right of Brooke, who had also crossed to the north bank on the pontoon bridge.

I feel that I cannot speak too highly of the bravery, soldierly conduct, and discipline displayed by Brooke's and Brown's brigades on this occasion. Attacked by an entire division of the enemy (Heth's), they repeatedly beat him back, holding their ground with unyielding courage until they were ordered to withdraw, when they retired with such order and steadiness as to merit the highest praise. Col. James A. Beaver, One hundred and forty-eighth Pennsylvania Volunteers, and Lieut. Col. D. L. Stricker, Second Delaware Volunteers, are particularly mentioned by Colonel Brooke for marked services and conspicuous courage.

The enemy regarded this as a considerable victory, and General Heth published a congratulatory order to his troops, indorsed by General Hill and General Lee, praising them for their valor in driving us from our intrenched lines. Had not Barlow's fine division (then in full strength) received imperative orders to withdraw, Heth's division would have had no cause for congratulation. There were no more than two brigades of Barlow's division engaged at any one time. When General Barlow commenced withdrawing his troops, I had directed General Birney to move his division to the right and occupy the heights on the north bank of the Po, commanding our bridges, in order to cover Barlow's crossing. The artillery, under command of Col. J. C. Tidball, chief of artillery, Second Corps, was placed in position for the same purpose. As soon as Brooke's and Brown's brigades had crossed the Po, General Barlow directed Colonel Smyth, commanding Second Brigade, to march his command across the pontoon bridge and take position immediately on the north side, where his fire would sweep the bridges in case the enemy designed forcing a passage. Miles' brigade was thus left to cross last and tear up the bridges at that point. I had sent a detachment to destroy the upper bridge, when the withdrawal was determined upon. The enemy now seeing but a few regiments remaining on the south bank, attempted to cross the open plain in their front, but were at once driven back by General Miles' troops and our artillery on the heights. A furious artillery fire was also opened by the enemy's batteries on the heights above the wooden bridge over the Po. Our batteries replied with a well-directed fire, which speedily silenced them, exploding one of their caissons, and forcing them to withdraw their guns. Miles' brigade now crossed to the north bank, taking up the pontoon bridge and thoroughly destroying the other. The enemy made no attempt to cross the stream.

Birney's division was then ordered to return to Warren's right, to take part in the assault which was ordered at 5 p. m., in front of Warren's position. Barlow's division remained on Birney's right, holding the ground it had occupied when it recrossed the river. Earlier in the day, about 11 a. m., Webb's and Carroll's brigades, of



Gibbon's division, had been engaged in an attack on the enemy's position, under the command of General Warren, in which they had suffered severely. At 5.30 p. m., when I returned to General Warren's front, I found the Fifth Corps and Gibbon's division, of the Second Corps, engaged in an assault on the enemy's line in front of Alsop's house. The enemy held the crest of a densely wooded hill, crowned by earth-works, his artillery and musketry sweeping his front. The approach to this position was rendered more difficult and hazardous by a heavy growth of low cedar trees, most of them dead, whose long, bayonet-like branches interlaced and pointing in all directions presented an almost impassable barrier to the advance of our lines. Here, as in the Wilderness, the woods prevented me from observing the conduct of the troops, although close to the point of attack; but it was soon evident that we had failed. The men struggled on bravely for a time and even entered the enemy's breast-works at one or two points, but soon wavered and fell back in some confusion. I speak particularly of the troops engaged of my own corps, as I have not had a report of the operations of his troops from General Warren. Gibbon's division reformed on the ground from which it had advanced to the attack. It lost heavily on this occasion.

I was directed by the major-general commanding to assault the enemy again at the same point at 6.30 p. m. My preparations for this attack had just been completed when I received an order from General Meade, by an officer of his staff, to defer my advance if the troops were not already in motion, and to move a strong force to the right of Barlow's position to oppose a heavy column of the enemy, which was reported to have crossed the Po, and to be advancing on our right flank. I had scarcely given instructions for the execution of this order when it was countermanded, and I was directed to proceed with the attack on the enemy's line in my front. The assault as formerly directed was then made by the Fifth Corps and portions of Gibbon's and Birney's divisions of the Second Corps. The troops encountered the same obstacle which had forced them to retire when they had assaulted this point at 5 p. m. They were again repulsed with considerable loss. Ward's brigade retired in disorder until rallied by my own staff and that of General Birney. The heavy firing did not cease until 7.30 p. m. The 11th of May passed without serious fighting for my command. Miles' brigade, of Barlow's division, made a reconnaissance on the Spotsylvania road as far as Todd's Tavern, but did not encounter the enemy. Two regiments were also thrown across the Po, to feel for the enemy in that direction. At 4 p. m. I received orders to move Birney's and Barlow's divisions at dark to a point near Mott's division, which was on the left of the Sixth Corps. I was further directed to form my troops for an assault on the enemy's line at 4 a. m., on the 12th. Lieutenant-Colonel Morgan and Major Mitchell, of my staff, accompanied Lieutenant-Colonel Comstock, of General Grant's staff, to reconnoiter the position, which I was instructed to storm, but owing to the uncertainty as to the exact point to be attacked, no very definite information was obtained.

Birney's and Barlow's divisions moved out after dark, under the guidance of Major Mendell, of the Engineers, over a narrow and difficult road during a heavy rain, which rendered the marching extremely fatiguing for the men. The head of the column arrived at the Brown house, near which it was proposed to form the troops for the attack about midnight, going into position as soon as they came

up. Gibbon's division was also sent me, so that I had my whole corps available for the assault. The troops were formed just in rear of our picket-line, about 1,200 yards from the enemy's intrenchments. But little was known of his position, an attempt made by General Mott, on the 11th, to drive in his skirmish line for the purpose of observation having been only partially successful. The ground ascended sharply between our lines and the enemy's, and was thickly wooded, with the exception of a clearing about 400 yards in width extending up to the enemy's works in front of the Landrum house, curving to the right as it approached his position; a small water course ran parallel to and in front of our line. The troops were formed for the assault with the assistance of the information obtained from Lieutenant-Colonel Merriam, Sixteenth Massachusetts Volunteers, field officer of the day for Mott's division, who was somewhat familiar with the ground. They took position quietly and promptly, although it was an unusually dark and stormy night.

The direction in which our troops should advance was ascertained by a line determined by a compass on the map from the Brown house toward a large white house known to be inside the enemy's works, near the point we wished to strike. The formation was as follows: Barlow's division in two lines of masses was placed on the cleared ground which extended up to the enemy's line; Brooke's and Miles' brigades in the front line, Brown's and Smyth's in the second line, each regiment forming double column on the center. Birney's division formed in two deployed lines on Barlow's right. In front of him was a marsh and a dense wood of low pines. Mott's division formed in rear of Birney. Gibbon was in reserve. These preparations were scarcely completed at daylight. A heavy fog decided me to delay the order for the assault to commence for a short time, until we should have sufficient light. I therefore waited until 4.35 a. m., when the order was given to advance. Birney had some difficulty in making his way through the marsh and wood in his front, but he pushed forward, overcoming all obstacles, keeping well up with Barlow's division, which moved at quick time for several hundred yards, his heavy column marching over the enemy's pickets without firing a shot, regardless of a sharp fire on its left flank from the enemy's picket reserve, which was posted on the high ground on which the Landrum house stands. It continued up the slope about half way to the enemy's line, when the men broke into a tremendous cheer, and spontaneously taking the double-quick, they rolled like an irresistible wave into the enemy's works, tearing away what abatis there was in front of the intrenchments with their hands and carrying the line at all points in a few moments, although it was desperately defended. Barlow's and Birney's divisions entered almost at the same moment, striking the enemy's line at a sharp salient immediately in front of the Landrum house. A fierce and bloody fight ensued in the works with bayonets and clubbed muskets. It was short, however, and resulted in the capture of nearly 4,000 prisoners of Johnson's division, of Ewell's corps, 20 pieces of artillery, with horses, caissons, and material complete, several thousand stand of small-arms, and upward of 30 colors. Among the prisoners were Maj. Gen. Edward Johnson and Brig. Gen. George H. Stuart, of the Confederate service. The enemy fled in great confusion and disorder. Their loss in killed and wounded was unusually great. The interior of the intrenchments presented a terrible and ghastly spectacle of dead, most of whom were killed